Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Edna St. Vincent Millay's "Inland"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's use of imagery in St. Vincent Millay's "Inland" include

alliteration,
caesura,
comparison,
connotation,
diction,
enjambment,
feminine rhyme,
imagery,
masculine rhyme,
melopoeia,
metaphor,
meter,
onomatopoeia,
parenthesis,
polyptoton,
rhetorical question,
rhyme scheme,
rhythm,
simile,
speaker,
theme, and
tone.

The young writer should recognize the immediate effect of auditory imagery, especially the repeated occurrence of onomatopoeia, which dominates the poem's melopoeia. The visual, olfactory, tactile, and gustatory imagery complement this effect, toward an understanding of the speaker's full sensory longing for the sea.

The visual complements the auditory through the first three stanzas and takes momentary precedence in the fourth stanza through a negation in line 14's "Neither a window nor a door." The visual imagery, implicit and explicit, of a house (in both the first and last stanzas) that suggests a man-chosen (inland) and manmade (house) isolation by way of the purchase of property (In light of the speaker's second rhetorical question, is line 2's *plot* suggestive?) upon which will sit a house whose narrow windowless and doorless walls (stanza 4) create a sharp, very rectangular, perhaps boxed-in, contrast to the fluidity and symbolic freedom of the sea.

The student-writer might comment on the claustrophobic effect ensured by both the tactile imagery and the visual imagery (negated) that lead to line 15's extreme plight, "Screaming to God for death by drowning."

The lit critter might notice that the imagery of isolation begins with the one-word title, and she might recognize in the speaker's curiosity (line 11's "What do they long for?") about the self-removal underlying people building their houses inland (line 1) a longing for the fully embodied experience of our primal relationship with the sea, a relationship that is echoed in the repetition that informs lines 8 and 16.